

Water usage in the US.... car washes or AI - what's worse?

Posted by u/littlepeachbigworld • 0 points • 9 comments

Genuinely curious about how much water is used for car washes in the USA... and how that compares to AI/data centers moving in? We hear a lot about the water usage of data center, especially in the Midwest, and just thinking large scale of another sort of business that uses a lot of water and car washes came to mind. I know many car washes use water reclamation and data centers would too. But the sheer amount of water that is used for a data center each day has to outweigh the amount used by car washes in the country..... right?

Anyone have any good math on this?

Comments

u/WeAreBlackAndGold • 1 points • 2025-12-06 00:46 UTC

Most car washes recycle the water.

u/AgentElman • 2 points • 2025-12-05 22:30 UTC

Washing a car at home uses 80-140 gallons of water.

For one gallon of water, ChatGPT can answer 11,765 queries.

u/CyndilsOnReddit • 2 points • 2025-12-05 22:26 UTC

I did a little googling and I'm not doing any sort of deep dive but I was curious so here's my half-assing:

Data centers use massive amounts of water daily, ranging from hundreds of thousands to millions of gallons, primarily for cooling servers through evaporative systems, with large facilities consuming up to 5 million gallons daily

And:

In the U.S., professional car washes use significantly less water than home washing, averaging 30 to 40 gallons **of fresh water per car** (or even as low as 9-15 gallons with recycling), while at-home washing can use 100+ gallons; a high-volume tunnel wash might use 48,000 gallons/day, whereas an in-bay automatic could use 3,500-7,000 gallons/day, thanks to modern water reclamation systems that reuse most water.

u/archpawn • 3 points • 2025-12-05 22:25 UTC

I found [this thing](<https://www.carblackoforlando.com/blog/what-is-the-average-amount-of-water-used-to-wash-a-car/>) giving amounts for different types of car wash. The kind I always think of is the friction in-bay automatic system, which is 35 gallons. The highest is 120 gallons. Googling around, ChatGPT uses about 5 to 500 mL per prompt, or about 8 to 800 prompts per gallon. For comparison, it takes about 130 gallons of water to make a cup of rice.

So, going by high estimates, a cup of rice is worth about one car wash or 1000 ChatGPT prompts.

u/uaonthetrack • 1 points • 2025-12-05 22:57 UTC

Do you mean 130 gallons of water to grow a cup of rice?

u/archpawn • 1 points • 2025-12-05 23:02 UTC

Yes.

u/MarsThrow • 1 points • 2025-12-05 22:09 UTC

>But the sheer amount of water that is used for a data center each day has to outweigh the amount used by car washes in the country..... right?

Correct. You bet your ass environmentalists would have a huge issue with car washes and complain about it constantly if it was actually an issue, but I have literally never heard that argument outside of drought areas.

u/archpawn • 2 points • 2025-12-05 22:31 UTC

In my experience, what people complain about is rarely the biggest issue. You hear about school shootings when those kill almost no one and most gun deaths are suicides. You hear about airplane crashes when cars are orders of magnitude more dangerous. You hear about low flush toilets and AI when the amount of water they use is trivial next to what kind of food you're eating.

u/shootYrTv • 1 points • 2025-12-05 22:09 UTC

The issue isn't exactly about the amount of water usage, but the water usage specifically in places where water is functionally a finite resource. The amount of data centers being built in the middle of the desert, especially in places like California, is much more harmful than the car washes in those areas by sheer volume. That's the harm they're causing to communities that are already water-insecure.